

1993 saw traditions laid aside and new ones made

It was a year of abandoning traditions and creating new ones.

Canadian Pacific Rail decided to close the rail line that has run through Almonte for more than 150 years. Starting in mid-1994, no one will be greeted by the late morning whistle warning as the trains roll through town.

The centrepiece of the downtown — the Old Post Office — was locked up and abandoned.

The groups who used the 104-year-old structure for the past three years — dispersed to the town hall, township hall and new museum site on Highway 15.

Canada Post had breathed new life into the building by fixing its clock. Now its rooms stand cold and empty through this frigid winter.

On a brighter note, entrepreneurs Greg Smith and Stéphen Brathwaite added a spark to the lower end of Mill Street by buying and opening the "Shoddy Mill Gallery."

While an August fire temporarily laid plans aside, the men are still committed to the old stone building that was abandoned two years ago.

The town hall auditorium got a facelift. Almonte beat Inuvik at their own game, showing them the town can win a fitness challenge given a year to warm up.

The Gazette covered many highs and lows through 1993. Here are some:

JANUARY

Parents said no but the Lanark County Board of Education said yes to all-day, alternate-day kindergarten. More than 400 parents said the days would be too long for young children.

However, facing cuts in grants for buses, trustees agreed to take out the mid-day bus runs for young students. The vote passed 15-2.

The Ministry of Transportation told Mike Cleary lights are not necessary at the Highway 17 intersection where his wife and a fellow commuter were killed in October, 1992. Minister Gilles Pouliot said lights would not have prevented the tragedy.

The Pakenham Community Association's founder insisted no one is trying to upstage the Recreation Association. Fred Millar told Pakenham Township Council his group would not divert funds from the cash-strapped recreation office.

Canadian National and Canadian Pacific railways announced plans to merge their rail lines through the Ottawa Valley, closing the one that runs through Almonte. Both companies said they would save thousands of dollars by no longer duplicating routes.

John Levi took over the helm of the Business Improvement Association. He cited a specific interest in revitalizing the downtown core, having contributed to that goal himself by declining an offer to move out to Highway 44.

FEBRUARY

Parents of children at St. Mary's School shouted down the option to bus older children to a new school in Carleton Place. Instead, they asked trustees to improve this St. Mary's. A group to look into that disbanded shortly afterward.

Corkery hit international air waves when NBC's "Unsolved Mysteries" broadcast part of a show about a supposed UFO sighting. UFO researcher Bob Oeschler was drawn here by an anonymous video tape from someone calling him or herself "Guardian."

Iber Homes opened its sales office to push Naismith Park, a new development along Highway 15. By year's end, a dozen or more families had moved into those homes.

Premier Bob Rae announced Almonte would receive \$2 million toward its water and sewer master plan.

An Ottawa fly fisherman was the first to sink temporary hooks into plans to

rehabilitate the Appleton dam. By objecting to rezoning, Bill Haigis said the higher water threatened an "irreplaceable" recreation gold mine. His and 17 other objections were lifted after developer Merv Olsheski altered his plans.

An MVCA spokesperson said local beaches were safe for swimmers in the summer of 1992. Laurel Grills told the Friends of the Mississippi levels of bacteria had been low all swimming season.

MARCH

Chris Lea opens a pool hall and drop-in centre for youths at the corner of Bridge and Mill Streets. He insists security will be tight and all intoxicants strictly banned.

The Mississippi Valley Textile Museum agrees to take in a large collection from the Museum of Science and Technology in Ottawa. The looms, carding machines and testing equipment are valued at \$750,000, according to museum property manager Alex Hughes.

Almonte's taxes take a two per cent jump as Ramsay and Pakenham Townships hold theirs to 1992 levels. Councillor Steve Maynard criticizes the process, saying only three areas suffered cutbacks: public works, daycare and the fire department.

Lanark County's education director Stuart Howard steps down facing ill health. Gerry Slinger moves up a notch from superintendent of schools to fill in until year end.

Lloyd and Mary Connolly of Almonte win \$250,000 in the 6-49 lottery on St. Patrick's Day. The couple say they intend to keep the same lifestyle, invest some money and share their riches with their family.

Tracey Prescott and Lonesome Daddy bring a Juno back to Clayton after winning the award for being the best country group in Canada.

APRIL

The county holds the tax increase to one per cent but sends back the waste reduction department's request for a 7.6 per cent hike in its budget.

The Liberals choose Ian Murray to lead them into the next election. After weeks of debate over the method of voting, Murray wins a coin toss over close opponent Paul LaRose-Edwards.

Hunters tell the Ministry of Natural Resources point-blank they don't like the proposed "shotguns only" proposal for local hunting areas. The ministry backs down in May.

The dairy princess is renamed the "dairy educator" for these more politically-correct times. The tiara and banner are replaced by a navy blazer.

Councillor Steve Maynard quits Almonte town council citing personal reasons. It was his first term.

MAY

Almonter Sean Egan leads a group of university students on a walk for children's rights from Toronto to Ottawa. They stop in Almonte briefly to speak at St. Mary's School.

Janet Brennan steps in as Almonte's new councillor. She promised to listen and learn before actively campaigning for certain causes.

Town council hands out a fourth taxi license despite loud opposition from driver Jim Dugdale. The fledgling company lasts less than two weeks.

The North Lanark Highland Games committee loses its parking lot at the end of Water Street as owner Brian Dryan protests council's lack of support for his rezoning. The cars use the arena parking



For several weeks, commuters put up with gravel roads where pavement used to lie on Highway 44. The asphalt was laid in mid-August.

lot instead with great praise from commuters.

Judie McKimmings wins the NDP nomination over Judith Spence, also of Kanata. It was the first time someone had contested a nomination in this riding's history.

Guy Lefebvre takes home the McGregor Award for business excellence. The co-owner of Stedmans was the previous chairman of the Business Improvement Association.

JUNE

In a bizarre accident, a teenager sends a car airborne, landing on top of two cars in the high school parking lot. Only the driver is injured. He was charged with careless driving.

Ron and Dwight Miller launch a \$110,000 lawsuit against Pakenham Township Council. The Millers allege the township's road superintendent promised certain improvements to their property in exchange for land to widen the road.

Davey Drummond calls off his annual "Jam in the Hills," blaming lack of co-operation from the town and police. In 1994 he plans to move the event to Ramsay Township.

Almonte out-sweats Inuvik in the second annual fitness challenge. Fifty-five per cent of Almonters exercised June 2 compared to Inuvik's 39 per cent.

Clayton Seniors Housing Corporation pulls its bid for rezoning after area residents protest far-reaching implications. The official plan amendment opens the door for multi-residential development across the township.

Councillor Garry Dalgity leads the charge to raise money to improve the arena. Only a handful show up for the first meeting, but others come forward to lay plans.

Drivers curse road workers as construction on Highway 44 seems to drag on forever. Many report damage to cars and wallets for car washes and repairs.

JULY

Crowds were sparse for daytime events but there was a huge turn-out for the fireworks display Canada Day.

Almonte 'super volunteer' Marie Seaman was honored with an Ontario Medal for Good Citizenship. She received her award from Lt.-Gov. Hal Jackman and Premier Bob Rae during a June 30 ceremony at Queen's Park.

A building used to store rental ski equipment at Mount Pakenham was gutted by fire July 8 after it was struck by lightning during a fierce storm. Damage estimate was placed at \$250,000.

It was the best of summer all rolled up in one weekend. The sun shone. The music played. Neighbors and friends met and chatted on the streets as Almonte hosted its 10th annual Ice Cream Festival July 16-18.

Pakenham council's tough year got even tougher when possible conflict of interest allegations were leveled at the township's deputy-reeve in mid-July. The issue surfaced at a time when council was debating a rezoning for the Linda Lowe Daycare Centre.

Later that month, a break-in at the Pakenham arena led to the resignation of Councillor Bill Whyte from the recrea-

tion association.

The search for a county landfill site was to be narrowed to two farms in Bathurst Township. A third site, in Drummond Township, was eliminated as an inappropriate location, according to a waste management committee report.

AUGUST

Quick work by Almonte-Ramsay firefighters with assistance from other departments, was being credited with preventing the total destruction of the Pincraft building following an early-morning fire Aug. 3.

No one has been charged with setting the blaze.

For the third time in the past decade, the treacherous Mississippi River rapids near the Five Span Bridge claimed a life. This drowning occurred in the afternoon of Aug. 1.

A succession of local business and municipal leaders assisted in the opening of the Naismith Visitors' Centre Aug. 3.

The province's social contract negotiations played havoc with public payrolls throughout the summer.

The Lanark County Board of Education, for example, had to cut \$1.9 million from its \$63 million budget forcing more spending cuts for the board, and unpaid days off for staff.

The heritage of basketball and the promise in young players collided on Bridge Street Saturday, Aug. 21, in the second annual Naismith/Hallas Three-on-Three Basketball Tournament.

SEPTEMBER

The Scottish weather gods smiled down on Almonte's "Friendly" Highland Games again this year.

As the busy schedule kicked off around 9 a.m., Aug. 28, at the fairgrounds, there was nothing but sunshine.

The county's public school board faced accusations Aug. 26 of practicing double standards in its treatment of high-school aged special education students.

At a public meeting in Smiths Falls, parents insisted their children deserved the same quality of education as "regular" students.

Following in the footsteps of their Renfrew counterparts, land owners are planning a way to buy the railroad right-of-way.

Canadian Pacific (CP) and Canadian National (CN) have struck a partnership that will move all train traffic to CN's Nipissing-Ottawa line. That makes CP's Mattawa-Smiths Falls link — which passes through Almonte — redundant.

The weather may have been chilly. But there were plenty of activities to warm the thousands of spectators at the 135th annual Almonte Fair Sept. 9-12.

Kim Campbell, Canada's first woman prime minister, made her first-ever, election campaign stop in Lanark County Sept. 8, providing an early boost for the campaign of veteran area MP Paul Dick.

In a letter from Ministry of Environment, Lanark County council was informed funding for the waste management master plan would be capped at \$800,000.

Doubt was raised whether the study would continue without the province's 50 per cent share.

Almonte councillors rejected a land

swap proposal from developer Bryant Cougle which would see him trade his eight hectares of land near the town lagoons for an equivalent sized lot in the industrial park. The developer hopes to build 200 units of affordable housing in town.

MP Paul Dick was given a rough ride late in the month by area public servants. Dick raised the ire of the Public Service Alliance of Canada (PSAC) when he declined an invitation to an all-candidates meeting on public service issues.

OCTOBER

A group of 16 parents decided there had been enough talk and not enough action about getting Almonte's teenagers off the streets when they invited youths to a meeting to get their input on possible solutions.

Pakenham reeve Harry Barr said at a public meeting the ongoing friction between council and the recreation association had the potential of forever removing volunteers from the community. The reeve called the meeting to get a clear indication from the public what direction recreation should take in the future.

More than 200 "Friendly Town" residents laid out the welcome mat for the contenders in the Lanark-Carleton race. Unlike other such gatherings in the county throughout the federal campaign, the local all-candidates meeting saw few sparks or surprises.

The Lanark County waste management committee called for the suspension of the eight-year search for a landfill site. The environment ministry terminated funding to the waste management master plan due to provincial budget constraints.

Liberal Ian Murray handed 21-year incumbent Tory Paul Dick a crushing defeat at the polls, winning the riding by a margin of more than 15,000 votes. In defeat, Dick blamed Reformers for splitting the Conservative vote and allowing Murray to sneak up the middle.



Enthusiasts from the fitness centre helped Almonte out-perform Inuvik in a fitness challenge. The two towns faced off June 2.

County council voted to suspend the eight-year-old \$1.6 million waste management master plan. With the study estimated to cost more than \$6 million before a county landfill was operational, councillors voted unanimously to suspend all activities related to the master plan.

Faced with escalating bussing costs and diminishing government grants, the tri-county separate school board announced it was studying a move to all-day, alternate day kindergarten. The proposal was among several to shave \$500,000 from the transportation budget.

NOVEMBER

The county hiked severance fees by 30 per cent to lessen an expected deficit in the land division department. Councillors voted in favor of the \$75 increase that saw the fees rise to \$350.

Participants in a land use workshop challenged rule-makers to allow for development that reflects Ramsay Township's rural character. They proposed common septic systems, wells and private, narrower roads to better use the land for agriculture, or woodlots.

A local developer urged the town to let its residents decide whether a proposed land swap deal should go through. Bryant Cougle, of Brylin Construction, suggested a swap to get his 20-year-old development — known as Dovercliffe Court — on track: his eight hectares off Highway 15 for the same amount of land in the town's industrial and commercial park.

Having exhausted most other funding avenues, the co-ordinators of the Almonte and District High School's gym expansion project turned to local government for a hand to put them over the top. Almonte and Ramsay councils were asked to commit a total of \$100,000 in the next two years.

The National Transportation Agency gave Canadian Pacific Railway the green light to abandon its 290-kilometre line between Smiths Falls and Mattawa as of July 1, 1994. Almonte's historic link with the railway will end on that day.

Appleton residents came, queried and listened at an environmental hearing into the abandoned Appleplex plant. They learned the building is full of garbage and chemicals strewn and spilled by vandals.

When polled for their comments, a majority of Pakenham council members favored passing on a municipal tax decrease to ratepayers.

Mississippi Valley Conservation Authority chairman Bill Van Kempen died Nov. 5. He was 65. Van Kempen started with the MVCA in 1979. He served as vice-chair from 1988-92 and took over the chairmanship in 1993.

DECEMBER

Almonte council turned down a Mississippi Valley Textile Museum proposal to enter into a partnership agreement. Council preferred to continue the present arrangement — offering an annual grant to assist in the museum's operation.

Lanark-Renfrew MPP Leo Jordan drafted a private member's bill which, if approved, would give towns and townships the power to make museum's exempt from taxes.

The architect hired to design an estimated \$280,000 elevator for Almonte's town hall confirmed it would provide access to all levels of the building. A tour with Derek Crain cleared up confusion some had over where and how people would disembark on the second floor.



Ron Caron showed up the "new" town hall auditorium after years of fundraising turned into weeks of renovations. The end result is stunning.